PLAUTO'S PALESTINIAN APOLOGY

A Play in One Act

by

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CAST OF CHARACTERS

Anas:	**A reflective and creative personality, passionate about freedom.**
Nour:	**A curious and brave individual seeking to learn and understand.**
Marah:	**A storyteller, bridging the past and present.**
Mohamed:	**A nurturing and determined individual.**
Abdullah:	**An enforcer of rules and societal borders.**

Scene

Various locations around the stage, symbolizing struggles and unity.

Time

The present, intertwined with reflections on the past.

ACT I

Scene 1

SETTING: We are in a refugee camp near the border wall between occupied Palestine and Egypt. There is an olive tree next to the border wall signifying the Palestinian side.

AT RISE: ANAS and MARAH are wearing a keffiyeh. NOUR is marveling at the keffiyeh in her hands. ANAS and MARAH tell NOUR about the keffiyeh in the middle of the stage. MOHAMED walks in from the audience left and nurtures the tree.

ANAS

Akhhh!

(ANAS sighs, feeling the keffiyeh NOUR shares with him and MARAH. He feels the keffiyeh proudly and respectfully.)

Do you know the name of this scarf? It's not just a scarf. It is a story of generations of resistance.

ANAS

The kufiya is the symbol of the struggle for freedom.

MARAH

The Kufiya is the symbol of Generational resistance.

ANAS

The kufiya is a symbol of the Palestinian cause.

ANAS (Cont.)

The one that displaced your parents out of Gaza to Egypt.

(NOUR's hand gently touching the scarf.)

NOUR

Can you put it on me?

MARAH

Come here.

(MARAH drapes the keffiyeh around NOUR's shoulders.)

ANAS

(Starts singing. His voice is steady but filled with deep longing and resonance)

جَفْرَا وَهِيَ يَا الرِّبْعُ
وِطِيْرُ الْحُبِ الشَّادِي
يُغَنِّي لِلسَّمَا الزَّرْقَا
فَلَسْطِينُ بِلَادِي
وِيَقُولُ الْقُدْسِ الْحُرَّةُ
تُحَرِّمُ عِ الْأَعَادِي
حَيْفَا وِيَافَا وِعَكَّا
وَالضِّفَّةُ الْغَرْبِيَّةُ

جَفْرَا وَهِيَ يَا الرِّبْعُ
فَلَسْطِينُ تِنَادِي
وَتِقُولُ يَا أَهْلَ النَّخْوَةِ
مُدُّوا لِيَ الْأَيَادِي

(The lights fade slightly. MARAH leaves off stage to care of the young children).

NOUR

(Sees MOHAMED and curiously jumps up and takes one walking step toward him, closer to the border.)

Do you think they might know!! Where did my parents go?!

MOHAMED

(MOHAMED is trying to care for the tree from his side, but he was not able to hear NOUR'S question)

ANAS

(Urgently, stepping in front of NOUR):

OHH No, NOUR!, it is really dangerous to get closer to that border.

NOUR

(NOUR is trying to make up sentences desperately.)

ANAS

Can't you remember Khalid last month - how he died!!

Just because he went close to the border.

(Lights turn red as soon as as NOUR gets one step closer to the border trying to touch the olive tree.)

ABDULLAH

(Comes running from right of the audience and grabs NOUR roughly, shoving her away from the border. He turns to ANAS striking him seriously, knocking him to the ground, and arrests NOUR.)

(BLACKOUT)

(END OF SCENE)

Scene 2

SETTING: **We are still near the border between occupied Palestine and Egypt. We cannot see the wall or tree. There is only a a single limited spotlight.**

AT RISE: **ANAS is alone and distressed on his back on the ground. He slowly gets up. He is in pain and breathing heavily as he searches for NOUR everywhere. The spotlight keeps trying to find and follow ANAS.**

ANAS

(Alone. Trying to get up)

Ahhkh, NOUR?!!
They...took NOUR too! They took her too

(Hardly jumps from his place, shouting the void)

–the dream...the future...!

(His voice falters, breaking into a whisper, his words heavy with grief.)

آآهخ ياربي ...

They took her too.

(slowly noticing the blood on the back of his head, while he is moving in place)

آهخ... , آآهخ... , آآهخ...

OK..

(Breathing earnestly, heavily and quickens from now on. He winces, slowly getting on his knees, and checking if he is safe in his position or not, slowly moving on his knees.)

ANAS (Cont.)

I'll write a message, and I'll put it?! I'll throw it next to the border. As someone might see it!!

(Half whispering, half crying, noticing the blood on him, when he gets into his knees trying to write the message)

اهخ دمم!!

(ANAS to himself and slowly gaining focus, with trembling hands, he pulls his keffiyeh from his shoulders. His movements are slow, deliberate. He drags his bloodied fingers across the fabric, smearing it as he writes. His voice grows stronger with each word, each stroke)

I'll keep this blood, and I'll keep it, I'll write this message from this blood.

(ANAS jumps, carefully looking around. He walks as if he has one and a half legs. He throws his keffiyeh with all his power to the other side of the border toward the olive tree. He has to tell the people on the other side of the border to gather and to help NOUR. He limps while leaving the stage carefully, not wanting to be seen by ABDULLAH).

(BLACKOUT)

(END OF SCENE)

Scene 3

SETTING: **We are near the border wall between occupied Palestine and Egypt. We see an olive tree next to the border wall. We see bars of a jail cell built on the occupied land.**

AT RISE: **The stage is in semi-darkness On the left side, we see NOUR trapped in jail, hands bound. ABDULLAH watches over her. NOUR is unyielding despite exhaustion; every now and then her gaze leaps toward the frontier and faraway tree**

MOHAMED

(He approaches the tree cautiously, looking over his shoulder. The stage brightens slightly as he kneels to water the roots. His gaze shifts to the keffiyeh thrones to the tree, its bloodstained note catching his attention.

MOHAMED carefully unties the keffiyeh and, quivering, he reads the bloodied keffiyeh notes. In an instant his face leaps from confusion to shock to grim determination in an instant. He looks around, holding the keffiyeh tightly.

MOHAMED

(whispering to himself):

From blood… They wrote this.

MOHAMED (Cont.)

(He rises suddenly as his voice grows louder, shouting and calling out to the unseen people "Counties" around him.

They've taken NOUR! (This cannot stand - This is not the first innocent we heard of... This needs us now!)

(Soft music starts to play from the back. MOHAMED steps toward the unseen people behind him, a spark of hope in every pull from his hands. Calling out for help.)

ANAS and MARAH

(ANAS and MARAH enter from the other side of the stage. Looking around with eyes filled with hope)

EVERYONE

(The music becomes louder. People start coming onstage from the border direction, as if the "countries" are crossing together. Everyone carries a peace symbol: olive branches and their country flags draped around them like lanterns (Egypt, Libya, Lebanon, Syria and Jordan). In a line, they move rhythmically with the song and on cue they cross the border.)

ABDULLAH

(Runs offstage questioning his actions)

EVERYONE

(Some struggle and help each other, Countries free NOUR from Jail. They welcome her and join ANAS in a line holding hands. Everyone sings.)

EVERYONE (Cont.)

Oh ooo oh

ANAS and MARAH
عابَ مجدَكَ بالمذلّة والهزائم حينما
هبّ الجنوبُ لكي يُقاوم
إنّ تاريخ الإباء غيرُ نائم
يكتبُ عن أرضِنا أرض الملاحِم

EVERYONE
عابَ مجدَكَ بالمذلّة و الهزائم

CHORUS
حينما هبّ الجنوبُ لكي يقاوم

EVERYONE
إنّ تاريخ الإباء غيرُ نائم

CHORUS
يكتبُ عن أرضِنا أرض الملاحِم

ANAS and MARAH
إنّ أهل العزمِ إن تدعى العزائم
هذا سيفي بالوغى بالموتِ قائم
إنَّ شعبي كلُّهُ وطنٌ مقاوم
ما ارتضى غيرَ المعزَّةِ و المكارم
إنّ أهل العزمِ إن تدعى العزائم
هذا سيفي بالوغى بالموتِ قائم
إنَّ شعبي كلُّهُ وطنٌ مقاوم
ما ارتضى غيرَ المعزَّةِ و المكارم

CHORUS
عابَ مجدَكَ بالمذلّة و الهزائم

EVERYONE
حينما هبّ الجنوبُ لكي يقاوم

CHORUS
إنّ تاريخ الإباء غيرُ نائم

EVERYONE
يكتبُ عن أرضِنا أرض الملاحِم

CHORUS

Ooh oo ooh

(BLACKOUT)
(END OF ACT)